

flag on the ceiling, five clocks, and a bank of computers operated by two women and two men. I listened as closely as I could, but didn't hear anybody mention a stock. Orton immediately ushered me into the glass-enclosed office that abutted the trading floor which reminded me of a waiting room for fathers in a maternity ward. I couldn't pick up any of the comments of the risk arbitrageurs from this side of the glass, but I tried to read lips.

In the corner of the room was a beanbag chair shaped like a baseball glove. On the table in front of us was a computer printout of all the stocks in which Orton and his staff currently were invested. I wanted to peek at it, but felt that it wouldn't be polite to snoop. There it was, a pile of potential profit, just inches from my fingertips. I stared at the printout as Orton answered a phone call.

"My mother," he said as he hung up the phone. "My mother asks me for a stock pick, says she wants action. Then I give her a stock pick, and the stock goes down a couple of points and she calls me to complain. What is this? Fuck her." He gave this speech as he paced frantically around the room, furiously chewing a wad of bubble gum.

I asked Orton if he exchanged ideas with fellow arbs, especially Ivan Boesky. "Guys call each other," he said. "Of course guys call each other. Take Viacom. Maybe I can call some guys and find out who is buying the stock. I might call a guy at Goldman, Sachs, and he might or might not tell me who's buying Viacom. Or I might ask one of the floor brokers. Most of the firms use the same floor brokers—who are you kidding?

"Take CBS. I just had dinner with a guy who says it'll go to \$180 in a year. It's what, \$125 now. You hear stuff like that all the time. The thing is, is it worth it?

"You can sometimes find out what's going on in a particular situation—what Boesky is doing, for instance. Sometimes he buys shares just to convince the rest of us he's on that side of a stock. Meanwhile, he's secretly selling through some other firm, so it turns out we're buying from him. I don't talk to Boesky directly. I don't talk to the Boesky people directly. No way I'd do that. They seem to keep to themselves."

Through the walls of the outer room I heard somebody yell